

sure that the diff-amp's outputs vary around V_{biasp} . The CMFB amplifier shouldn't affect the differential amplification in the diff-amp. When the diff-amp's outputs are equal (the inputs to the diff-amp are equal and neglecting offsets), they should be V_{biasp} .

Figure 26.9 shows one possible implementation of a CMFB amplifier. When the + inputs (noticing the PMOS connected to these inputs have half the width of the other PMOS) are equal to V_{biasp} , the currents that flow in M1 and M2 are $20\ \mu\text{A}$. This provides the proper mirroring action to the diff-amp (M3L, R) in Fig. 26.8. If the average of the + inputs moves above the - input, the current flowing in M2 decreases and the current in the 200/1 PMOS increases. This causes V_{CMFB} to increase. The result is that M3L and M3R turn on more and pull both of the outputs in Fig. 26.8 down (until their average is equal to V_{biasp}). Several concerns exist with this topology. To begin, whenever we employ feedback, we must be concerned with stability. To stabilize the CMFB loop, we can add capacitors to the outputs of the diff-amp (inputs to the CMFB amplifier). We may be able to stabilize the CMFB loop by adding capacitors to the CMFB amplifier's outputs. However, since we will need compensation capacitors for compensating the differential action of the op-amp, we might as well use these capacitors for both loops. The other concern with the CMFB amplifier in Fig. 26.9 is the input common-mode range. When the CMFB amplifier's + inputs move significantly away from the - input, we don't get the correct balancing. This keeps large signal swings on the diff-amp's outputs in Fig. 26.8 from being balanced around V_{biasp} .

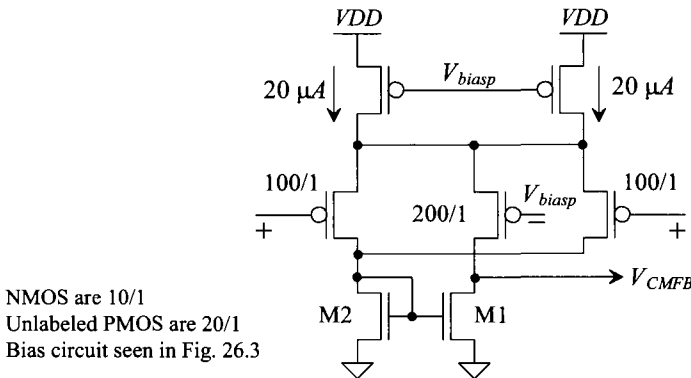
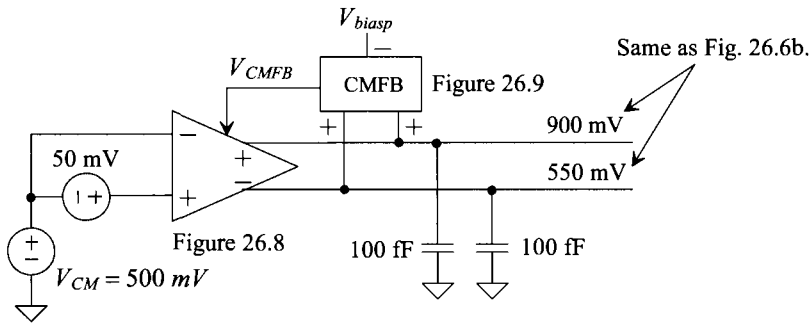
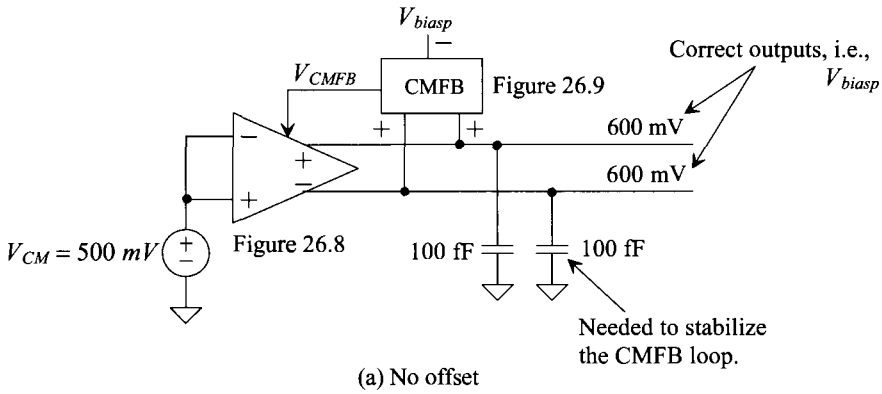


Figure 26.9 Implementation of the CMFB amplifier in Fig. 26.8.

Figure 26.10 shows simulation results using the CMFB amplifier in Fig. 26.9 with the amplifier in Fig. 26.8. The addition of the capacitors stabilizes the CMFB loop (*we need to discuss this further*). In (a) we see the correct balancing. The CMFB loop adjusts the diff-amp's output voltages to V_{biasp} . In (b) we re-simulate with an offset and see that the CMFB circuit isn't balancing the outputs. If it were, we would see one output above V_{biasp} by some amount and the other output below V_{biasp} by the same amount. With these output voltages (the inputs to the CMFB amplifier), one of the PMOS devices on the input of the CMFB is off and we don't get proper amplifier action. *We must use a CMFB circuit that can balance the outputs over the entire range of diff-amp output voltages.*



(b) With a 50 mV offset. Note how the CMFB isn't doing anything.

Figure 26.10 Simulating the operation of the CMFB circuit in Fig. 26.9.

Compensating the CMFB Loop

Consider the schematic seen in Fig. 26.11. The diff-amp behaves like an operational transconductance that can be compensated, as discussed in Sec. 24.3 (see Eq. [24.44]). The CMFB loop can be compensated in a similar fashion. The AC common-mode signal is represented in this schematic as v_c . If the gain of the CMFB amplifier is A_{cm} , then following the procedure leading to Eq. (24.44), we can write the unity-gain frequency of the CMFB loop as

$$f_{un,cm} = \frac{A_{cm} \cdot g_{mn}}{2\pi C_L} \quad (26.2)$$

If we want to compensate the CMFB loop with the same load capacitance used to compensate the differential forward signal path, then we must ensure that the gain of the CMFB amplifier is less than or equal to unity,

$$A_{cm} \leq 1 \quad (26.3)$$

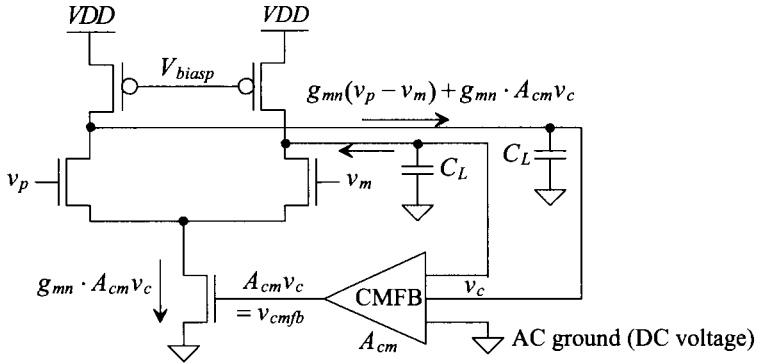


Figure 26.11 Schematic view of differential and CM feedback.

Reviewing the CMFB amplifier in Fig. 26.9 that has a current mirror active load, we see that A_{cm} is greater than 1. Removing the capacitors in Fig. 26.10 and resimulating will show that the CMFB loop is unstable. The added capacitors are relatively large and will overcompensate the differential signal path of the diff-amp. What we need to do is reduce the gain of the CMFB amplifier or reduce the CMFB loop's forward gain.

Towards reducing the gain, examine the CMFB amplifier seen in Fig. 26.12. This is the same amplifier topology seen in Fig. 26.9 except that here we've used a diode-connected load instead of a current mirror load (to reduce the gain). The schematic is drawn symmetrical around its center for ease of layout, as discussed earlier. Note that we used the common-mode voltage in this schematic, V_{CM} , as the voltage that the outputs of the amplifier will swing around (the more general case) rather than V_{biasp} as used in Fig. 26.10. Using this CMFB amplifier in the circuits of Fig. 26.10 (where the diff-amp of Fig. 26.8 has a low gain) won't precisely balance the outputs. The loop gain around the CMFB loop isn't large enough for proper operation. As we saw in Ch. 24, low first-stage gain can be remedied by using a telescopic input (cascode-load diff-amp) or a folded-cascode OTA. The other problem with this CMFB amplifier, again, is the limited allowable swing on the + inputs. As we've already seen, the input common-mode range limits the range of output voltages this CMFB can balance properly.

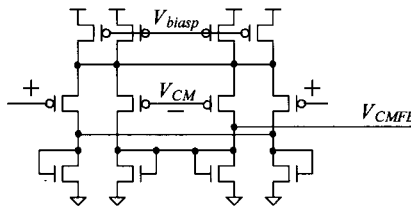


Figure 26.12 A CMFB amplifier with a gain of nominally unity.

Towards reducing the CMFB loop's forward gain, consider breaking the diff-amp's tail current up into parts, as seen in Fig. 26.13. The CMFB signal is applied to only one gate of the tail current. When compared to the topology in Fig. 26.8, the forward gain of the CMFB loop is halved. Further reduction can be implemented by adjusting the sizes of the transistors to further reduce the strength of the V_{CMFB} signal. *This is a common practical way of making CMFB loops stable.*

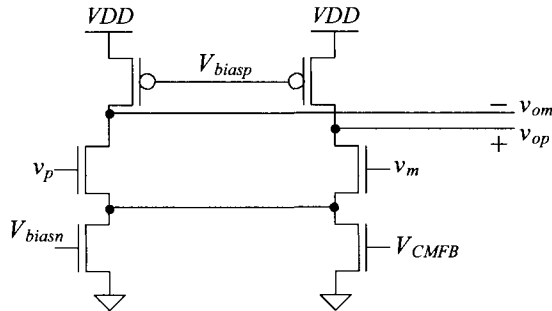
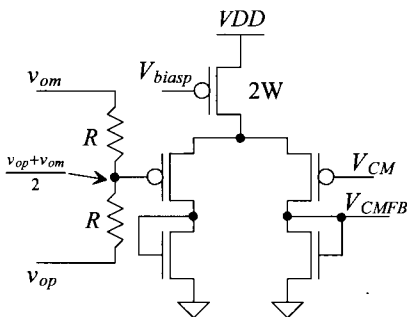


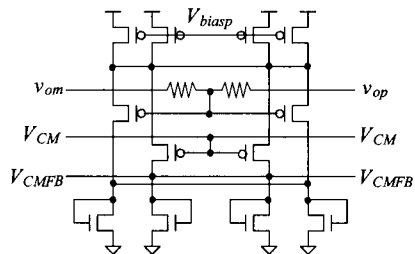
Figure 26.13 Reducing the forward gain of the CMFB loop.

Extending the CMFB Amplifier Input Range

The problem with the previous CMFB amplifier topologies based on a diff-amp is the diff-amp's limited input range. It's desirable to have a CMFB amplifier that functions over the entire range of possible amplifier output voltages. Towards this goal, consider the conceptual schematic in Fig. 26.14a. The resistors average the two outputs. This average is compared with the common-mode voltage (or a bias voltage as used in Fig. 26.8). Figure 26.14b shows the practical implementation of the amplifier for symmetry (at the cost of extra power dissipation). The practical problem with this topology is the



(a) Using resistors to average differential output signals.



(b) Symmetrical implementation of the CMFB circuit in (a).

Figure 26.14 Increasing CMFB amplifier input range.

loading by the resistors. If we were to connect this CMFB amplifier in the circuit configuration of Fig. 26.8, the resistors, unless they are huge ($>100k$) would load the differential amplifier and lower its gain. This topology is used, most often, on the output of an op-amp that has output buffers (and can thus drive resistive loads).

When using resistors for averaging in high-speed applications, we may have some parasitic effects that should be considered. The output signals have to charge, through the averaging resistors, the input capacitance of the MOSFET, as seen in Fig. 26.15. To ensure that the balancing action works at high speeds, capacitors (shown dashed in the figure) can be added, shunting the resistors. These capacitors can be very important if the size of the resistors is increased to reduce their loading on the output of the amplifier.

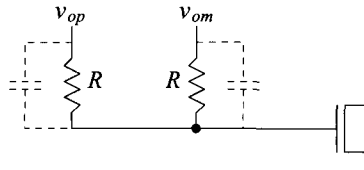


Figure 26.15 Adding parasitic capacitances across the resistors to compensate for the input capacitance of the MOSFET.

Dynamic CMFB

Figure 26.16 shows a switched-capacitor (SC) implementation of a CMFB circuit. The clocks, as in all SC circuits, are nonoverlapping (never high at the same time) clock signals, as seen in Fig. 25.28. The SC resistors are formed with the C_1 capacitors. The C_2 capacitors are used for the high-speed averaging just discussed (the dashed capacitors in Fig. 26.15). The SC resistors, as we'll see in a moment, perform both the averaging and the differencing needed in a CMFB amplifier. If the ϕ_2 controlled switches connected to amplifier's outputs, v_{op} and v_{om} , are transmission gates, the circuit can provide balancing from V_{DD} to ground.

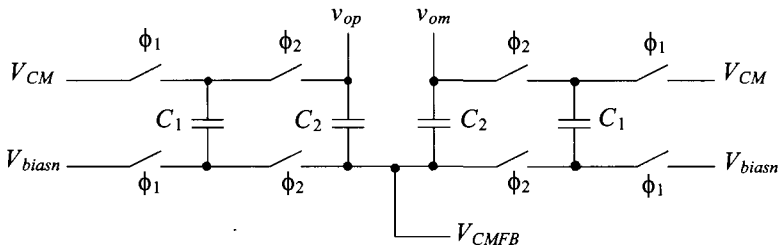


Figure 26.16 A switched-capacitor CMFB circuit.

26.3 Basic Op-Amp Design

Reviewing the data in Table 9.2, we see that the open circuit gains are 25 (NMOS) and 50 (PMOS). In this chapter we both increased the biasing current and reduced the channel length from the values used in Table 9.2. Each of these changes has the effect of reducing the MOSFET's open circuit gain. If, for example, the open circuit gains are both now 10, then a common-source amplifier with current source load will have a gain of 5. A cascode amplifier will have a gain of 25, and a two-stage op-amp using a cascoded first-stage a gain of only 125. In other words, we adjusted our biasing for high-speed operation but we are going to face some issues with getting large open-loop gain.

This is a good time to remember the useful simulation netlists that we've developed. Figure 26.18 shows the IV curves, output resistance, and transconductance for a 10/1 NMOS and a 20/1 PMOS based on Figs. 9.31 to 9.33. Notice in (a) that the NMOS's drain current at a V_{GS} of 400 mV and a V_{DS} of 100 mV is approximately 13 μA . The PMOS's drain current under the same conditions, (b), is closer to 9 μA . In (c) and

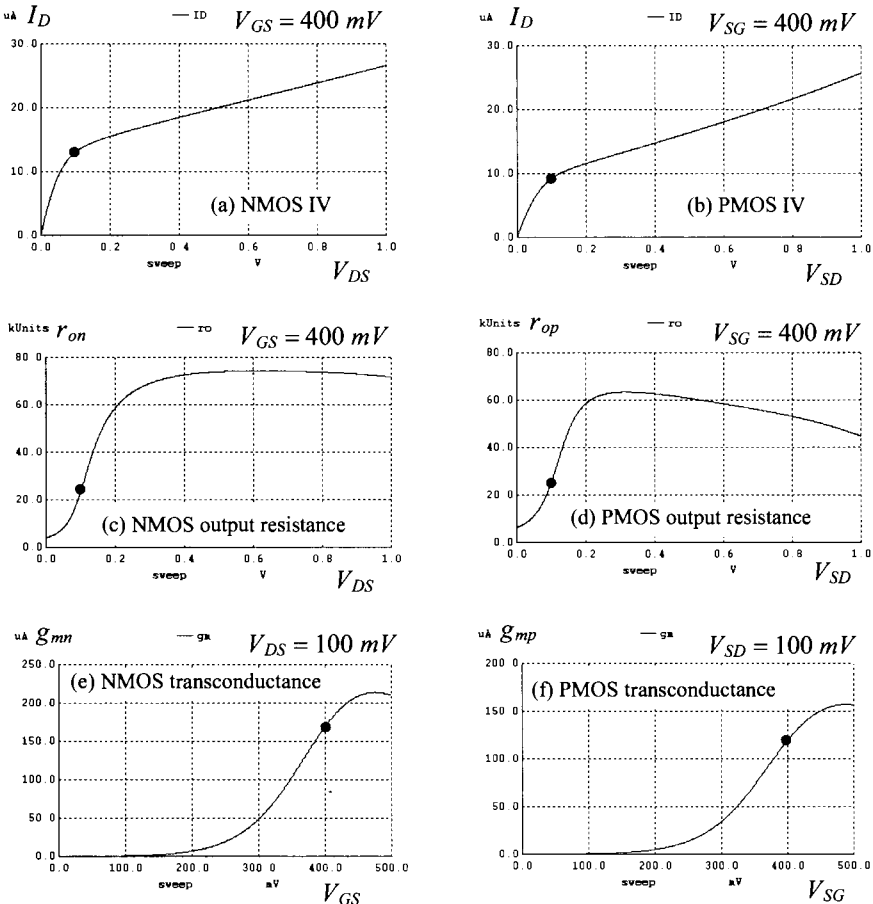


Figure 26.18 Characteristics of NMOS (10/1) and PMOS (20/1) devices.

(d), at a V_{DS} of 100 mV, the output resistance is only 25k. Using the transconductances in (e) and (f), the open circuit gains are, roughly, 4.375 (NMOS) and 3.125 (PMOS). In the actual circuits, the biasing points will vary (but in any case the gain of single stages will be low).

The Differential Amplifier

Figure 26.19 shows a cascode load diff-amp based on the topology seen in Fig. 26.7. Seen in the figure are typical values for the voltages in the circuit assuming gate-source voltages of 400 mV and, for the bottom two rows of NMOS devices, drain-source voltages of 100 mV. Notice how we used V_{biasn} to bias the second row of PMOS devices, which puts 200 mV across the drain-source voltages of the PMOS devices. This results in larger gain and reduced output swing. Diff-amp output swing is not an issue if this amplifier is used as the first-stage in a two-stage op-amp.

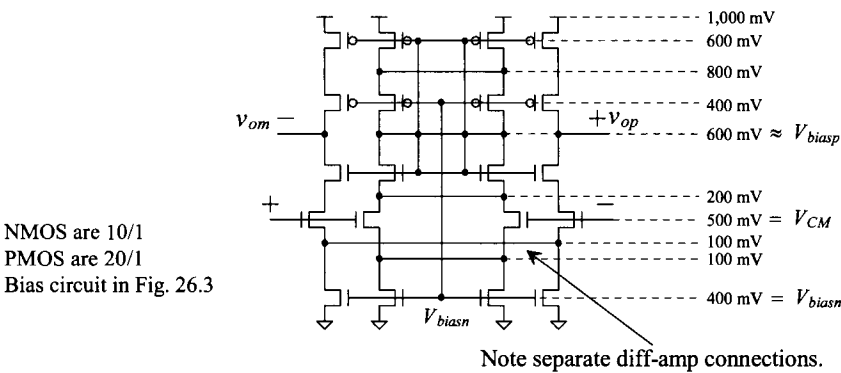


Figure 26.19 Fully-differential cascode diff-amp.

Figure 26.20 shows how the output voltages of the diff-amp in Fig. 26.19 vary with changes in V_{CM} . A 200 mV change in the common-mode voltage results in a, roughly, 50 mV change in the diff-amp's common-mode output voltages. Looking at Fig. 26.1, we see that the change in the drain current will be, again roughly, $\pm 5 \mu A$ around the quiescent value set with V_{CM} equal to 500 mV.

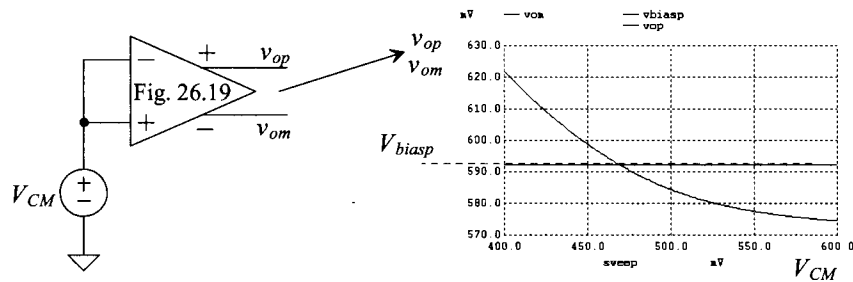


Figure 26.20 Varying the common-mode voltage and looking at the output.

Figure 26.21 shows the DC characteristics of the diff-amp. The gain is approximately 40. An important concern is how the mismatches in the MOSFETs used in the diff-amp affect the operation and biasing of the amplifier. Before discussing this issue, let's add the second stage and CMFB circuitry to form an op-amp. Note that, with a diff-amp gain of 40, and a second stage gain of 10, our op-amp's open loop gain will only have a value in the hundreds.

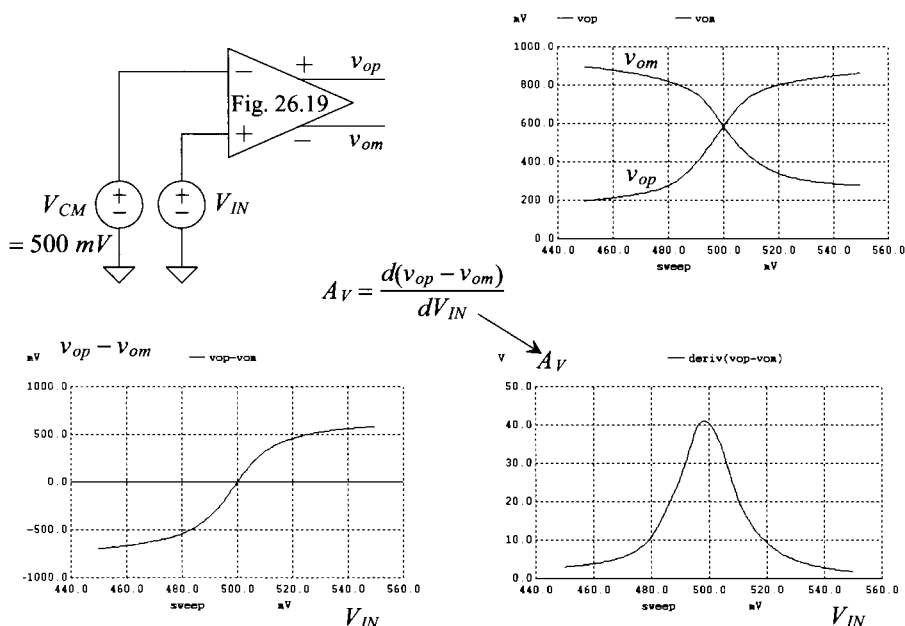


Figure 26.21 DC behavior and gain of the diff-amp in Fig. 26.19.

Adding a Second Stage (Making an Op-Amp)

Figure 26.22 shows a two-stage op-amp without CMFB circuit. The second stage of the op-amp operates class AB, as seen in Fig. 26.2, and the associated discussion. We've spent a considerable amount of time discussing how the output voltages of the diff-amp are approximately V_{biasp} . It should be clear after studying the op-amp in Fig. 26.22 why this is important. This voltage sets the quiescent current flowing in the output stages. There are eight vertical branches in this op-amp, so we can estimate the current pulled from V_{DD} under quiescent conditions as $160\text{ }\mu\text{A}$.

We used 50 fF capacitors for compensation in this op-amp. We can estimate the slew-rate limitations caused by the diff-amp driving the compensation capacitor, Eq. (22.34), as $20\text{ }\mu\text{A}/50\text{ fF} = 400\text{ mV/ns}$. Using a class AB output stage, we don't have slew-rate limitations associated with driving a load capacitance from a constant current source. As discussed at the beginning of the chapter, the output MOSFET's drain currents can be pulsed to a value greater than $100\text{ }\mu\text{A}$. When the op-amp is driving a 250 fF capacitive load, the speed limitations associated with charging the load capacitance are similar to the limitations we get when the diff-amp drives the compensation capacitor.

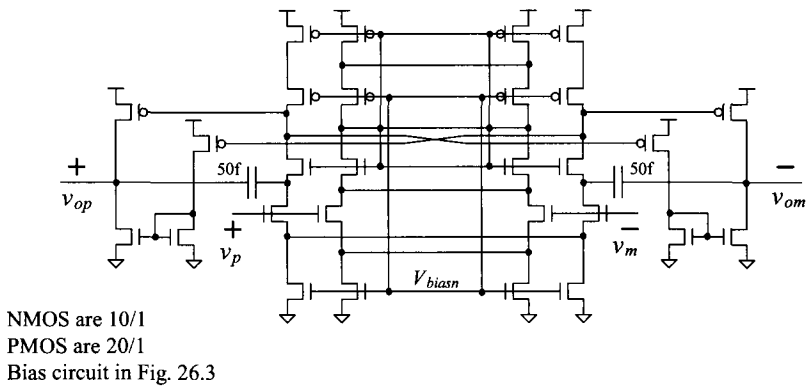


Figure 26.22 Basic two-stage op-amp without CMFB.

Figure 26.23 shows the DC characteristics of the op-amp in Fig. 26.22 where, once again, we've held the inverting op-amp input at the common-mode voltage and swept the voltage on the noninverting input. Notice how the outputs swing all the way from ground to $V_{DD} (= 1\text{V})$. Further notice how the differential output voltage swings from -1 to $+1\text{ V}$ (a doubling in the output swing as discussed in Sec. 25.2.) The op-amp's DC gain is approximately 500 without a DC load. Notice how the two op-amp outputs cross at 400 mV (not at V_{CM} where they should). We'll discuss the CMFB in a moment.

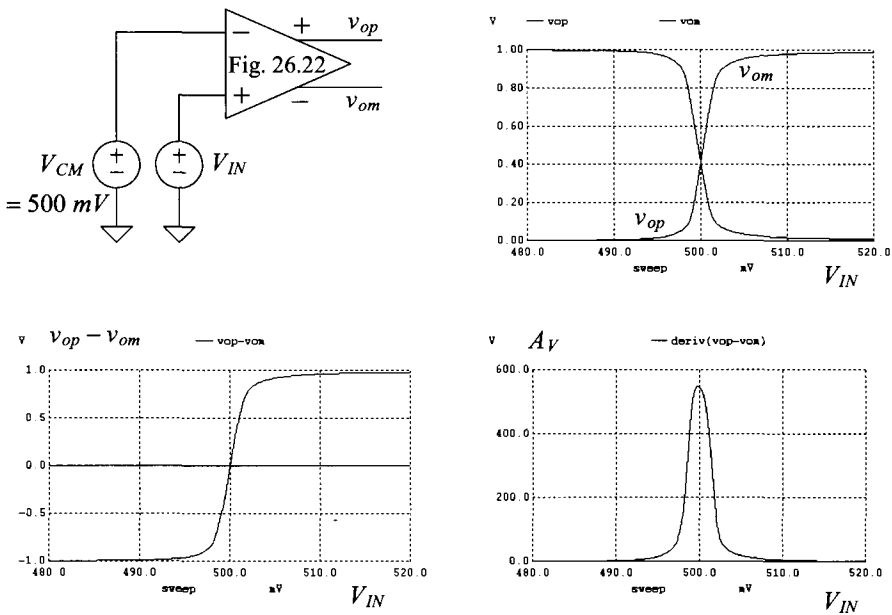


Figure 26.23 DC behavior and gain of the op-amp in Fig. 26.22.

Step Response

To determine both the stability of the op-amp in Fig. 26.22 and the settling time under certain loading conditions, consider the configuration seen in Fig. 26.24. We used relatively small resistors, 20k, in this circuit to reduce the RC time constant associated with the outputs of the op-amp charging the input capacitance of the op-amp. If, for example, the input capacitance of the op-amp is 25 fF (from parasitics and the MOSFETs used on the op-amp's input), then the RC time associated with charging this capacitance through a 20k resistor is 0.5 ns. As seen in Fig. 26.24, the settling time is approximately 2.5 ns so this RC time can have a significant effect on the settling time and stability of the circuit (important).

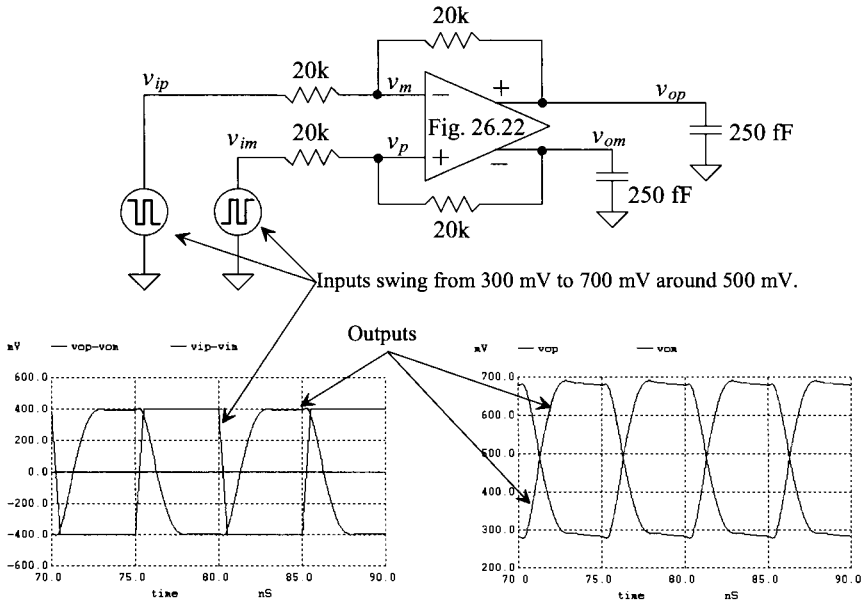


Figure 26.24 Step response of the op-amp in Fig. 26.22 driving 250 fF load capacitors and 20k feedback resistors.

Notice how, in Fig. 26.24, we used input signals that don't swing rail-to-rail. Since we don't have a CMFB circuit in the op-amp, the exact common-mode output voltage is an unknown. It may be 400 mV or it may be 600 mV. We get some help in setting the circuit's output common-mode level by using input signals with common-mode voltages of 500 mV and DC feedback. Looking at the simulation results in Fig. 26.24, we might get a false sense of not needing a CMFB circuit. To illustrate this is indeed a false sense, consider the sample-and-hold seen in Fig. 26.25 (see also Fig. 25.19). When the ϕ switches are closed, the op-amp's inputs and outputs should be held to $V_{CM} \pm V_{OS}$ (the op-amp is placed in the follower configuration). As seen in the figure, the outputs during this time are driven close to 400 mV. On closer inspection, we see the output common-mode level is wandering downwards until eventually the op-amp shuts off.